

FREE RESOURCE · AI & FINANCE AUTOMATION

Finance Automation Readiness Assessment

A 20-question self-assessment for finance teams evaluating readiness for AI and automation — covering data quality, skills, governance, and process maturity. Score your team, identify your readiness level, and find your recommended next steps.

20 questions	4 dimensions	5 readiness levels	Next steps per level
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HOW TO COMPLETE THIS ASSESSMENT

Answer all 20 questions honestly, selecting the option that best reflects your current situation — not where you aspire to be. For each question, circle or note the score (1–5) that matches your answer. Total your scores at the end of each section and on the summary scorecard. Use your total score to identify your readiness level and the recommended next steps for your team.

SCORING GUIDE

- 1 — Not in place
- 2 — Early stage
- 3 — Developing
- 4 — Established
- 5 — Advanced

Select the score that most accurately describes your current position. If you are between two options, choose the lower score.

Dimension 1 — Data Quality & Availability

Questions 1–5

Automation and AI tools are only as good as the data they process. This dimension assesses whether your finance data is structured, consistent, and accessible enough to support automation. Poor data quality is the most common reason finance automation projects fail or underdeliver.

01 How would you describe the consistency of your finance data across systems?

Data Quality

- | | |
|--|---|
| <p>1 Data is inconsistent across systems — the same metric has different values depending on where you look</p> <p>3 Core finance data is mostly consistent; some legacy or manual exceptions remain</p> <p>5 Data is fully consistent, governed by a data dictionary, and validated automatically on entry</p> | <p>2 Some key data is consistent but significant gaps and discrepancies remain in non-core areas</p> <p>4 Data is consistent across primary systems with documented exceptions and a remediation plan</p> |
|--|---|

My score:

02 How structured and standardised is your chart of accounts?

Data Quality

- | | |
|---|--|
| <p>1 The chart of accounts has grown organically and is inconsistent across entities</p> <p>3 A group chart of accounts exists and most entities follow it, with some exceptions</p> <p>5 Fully standardised, regularly reviewed, with mandatory coding validation at point of entry</p> | <p>2 There is a nominal group chart of accounts but entities deviate significantly from it</p> <p>4 A standardised chart of accounts is enforced across all entities with a controlled exception process</p> |
|---|--|

My score:

03 How accessible is your finance data for extraction and analysis?

Data Access

- | | |
|---|---|
| <p>1 Data is locked in systems that require IT to extract — self-service is not possible</p> <p>3 Most finance data can be extracted by the team via standard reports, though formats vary</p> <p>5 Data is available via APIs or live connections — no manual extract required for standard reporting</p> | <p>2 Some data can be extracted by finance, but it requires significant manual processing before use</p> <p>4 Finance has self-service access to structured data extracts in consistent, usable formats</p> |
|---|---|

My score:

04 How complete and accurate is your master data (cost centres, suppliers, employees, projects)?

Master Data

- | | |
|-----------------|--|
| <p>1</p> | <p>2 Master data is partially maintained but lacks a consistent owner or update process</p> |
|-----------------|--|

Master data is incomplete, duplicated, or outdated — it cannot be relied upon for automation

- 3 Core master data is maintained, with regular review for primary entities
- 5 Master data is governed centrally, validated automatically, and maintained in real time

- 4 Master data has defined owners, a maintenance process, and periodic validation

My score:

05 How well integrated are your core finance systems with each other?

Integration

- 1 Systems are siloed — data is moved between them manually via spreadsheets or rekeying
- 2 Some interfaces exist but they are unreliable, poorly documented, or require manual intervention
- 3 Core systems are integrated for primary data flows; some manual steps remain at the edges
- 4 Core systems are well integrated with stable, monitored interfaces and exception handling
- 5 All primary systems are integrated via API or middleware, with automated reconciliation and alerting

My score:

DIMENSION 1 TOTAL (MAX 25)

Dimension 2 — Skills & Digital Literacy

Questions 6–10

Automation tools require finance teams to develop new skills — from data analysis and Excel automation to understanding AI tool outputs and prompt engineering. This dimension assesses your team's current capability and learning orientation.

06 How would you rate the Excel and data skills of your finance team overall?

Excel / Data

- | | |
|---|--|
| <p>1 Basic — the team uses Excel for data entry and simple formatting, rarely for analysis</p> <p>3 Competent — the team builds workable models; some individuals use Power Query or macros</p> <p>5 Advanced — the team uses Power Query, Power BI, and at least one scripting or automation tool</p> | <p>2 Intermediate — the team uses formulas and pivot tables but struggles with complex models</p> <p>4 4 Strong — the team regularly uses Power Query, dynamic arrays, and structured data models</p> |
|---|--|

My score:

07 How familiar is your finance team with AI tools such as ChatGPT, Microsoft Copilot, or Google Gemini?

AI Literacy

- | | |
|--|--|
| <p>1 Not familiar — the team has little or no experience with AI tools</p> <p>3 Occasional users — some team members use AI tools for specific tasks but not systematically</p> <p>5 Proficient — the team uses AI tools strategically, writes effective prompts, and validates outputs</p> | <p>2 Aware but not using — the team has heard of AI tools but uses them rarely or experimentally</p> <p>4 Regular users — most of the team uses AI tools as part of their regular workflow</p> |
|--|--|

My score:

08 Does your finance team have experience with workflow automation tools (e.g. Power Automate, Zapier, or similar)?

Automation

- | | |
|--|---|
| <p>1 No experience — the team is not aware of or has not used automation tools</p> <p>3 Some experience — the team has run basic automations for notifications or simple routing tasks</p> <p>5 Embedded — automation is a standard part of how the team operates, with documented flows and governance</p> | <p>2 Limited awareness — one or two individuals have explored automation tools independently</p> <p>4 Regular use — the team actively uses automation for recurring tasks in the finance workflow</p> |
|--|---|

My score:

09 How does your finance team respond to learning new technology tools?

Learning Culture

- | | |
|-----------------|--|
| <p>1</p> | <p>2 Cautious — the team will adopt tools when required but does not actively seek them out</p> |
|-----------------|--|

Resistant — the team prefers established processes and views new tools with significant scepticism

3 Open — the team is generally receptive to new tools when the benefit is clearly demonstrated

5 Pioneering — the team actively drives technology adoption and shares learning across the function

4 Proactive — team members regularly seek out and test new tools relevant to their work

My score:

10 Does your organisation invest in digital and AI skills development for finance professionals?

Investment

1 No — there is no structured investment in digital skills for finance

2 Ad hoc — individuals occasionally attend training but there is no systematic programme

3 Developing — some structured training exists but coverage across the team is uneven

4 Established — a digital skills programme exists with budget, content, and participation tracking

5 Leading — digital and AI skills development is a strategic priority with regular, structured investment

My score:

DIMENSION 2 TOTAL (MAX 25)

Dimension 3 — Process Maturity & Documentation

Questions 11–15

You cannot automate a process you have not documented. This dimension assesses how well your finance processes are defined, standardised, and understood — the foundation that determines whether automation will embed reliably or simply replicate existing chaos at speed.

11 How well documented are your core finance processes (e.g. month-end close, expense processing, AP, reporting)?

Documentation

- | | |
|---|--|
| <p>1 Undocumented — processes exist in people's heads and vary by individual</p> <p>3 Core processes are documented, though not all are current or consistently followed</p> <p>5 All core processes are documented, version-controlled, and regularly reviewed for accuracy</p> | <p>2 Partially documented — some key processes are written up but coverage is incomplete</p> <p>4 Processes are documented, maintained, and accessible to the team</p> |
|---|--|

My score:

12 How standardised are your finance processes across entities or business units?

Standardisation

- | | |
|--|--|
| <p>1 Each entity operates its own processes — no meaningful standardisation exists</p> <p>3 Group standards cover primary processes; entities have latitude on secondary processes</p> <p>5 Fully standardised across all entities with monitored compliance and a continuous improvement process</p> | <p>2 Some group standards exist but local variation is the norm rather than the exception</p> <p>4 Processes are standardised across entities with a defined exception and deviation process</p> |
|--|--|

My score:

13 How much of your finance team's time is spent on repetitive, rule-based manual tasks?

Manual Work

- | | |
|---|--|
| <p>1 The majority of finance team time — more than 60% — is spent on manual, repetitive tasks</p> <p>3 Around 20–40% is manual; the team would benefit from significant automation</p> <p>5 Less than 10% is manual; the team spends most of its time on analysis and decision support</p> | <p>2 A significant proportion — 40–60% — is manual and repetitive</p> <p>4 Less than 20% is manual; most routine tasks have already been partially automated</p> |
|---|--|

My score:

14 How clearly defined are the decision rules in your key finance processes (e.g. approval thresholds, coding rules, escalation triggers)?

Rules & Logic

- | | |
|-----------------|---|
| <p>1</p> | <p>2 Some rules are written down but coverage is partial and exceptions are common</p> |
|-----------------|---|

Decision rules are informal and applied inconsistently — outcomes depend on who is handling the task

3 Primary decision rules are defined and reasonably consistently applied

5 Decision rules are fully documented, version-controlled, and enforced by system controls where possible

My score:

4 Decision rules are clearly documented, systematically applied, and subject to periodic review

15 How effectively does your finance function measure and track its own process performance?

Measurement

1 Process performance is not tracked — we do not have visibility of cycle times, error rates, or costs

3 Key process metrics are tracked and reviewed at least quarterly

5 Real-time process dashboards exist; performance data drives continuous improvement decisions

2 Some metrics exist but they are produced manually and reviewed infrequently

4 Process performance is measured monthly with clear KPIs and improvement targets

My score:

DIMENSION 3 TOTAL (MAX 25)

Dimension 4 — Governance & Stakeholder Readiness

Questions 16–20

Technology is the smallest part of a finance automation programme. Leadership support, clear ownership, change management capacity, and vendor management capability determine whether automation embeds or is quietly abandoned after go-live. This dimension assesses your organisation's readiness to drive and sustain change.

16 How strong is senior leadership support for finance automation in your organisation?

Leadership

1 No visible support — leadership has not prioritised or invested in finance automation

2 Passive support — leadership does not oppose it but has not committed resources or attention

3 Moderate support — leadership has expressed interest and is open to investment proposals

4 Active support — leadership has committed budget, endorsed the programme, and is visibly sponsoring it

5 Strong sponsorship — automation is a board-level priority with a named executive sponsor and formal governance

My score:

17 Does your organisation have a clear owner for finance automation — someone with authority and accountability for delivery?

Ownership

1 No named owner — automation initiatives are informal and lack a single accountable person

2 Ownership is informal — someone leads by default but without a mandate or formal accountability

3 An owner has been identified but does not yet have full authority or dedicated time

4 A named owner with authority and dedicated resource exists for the automation programme

5 A formally mandated programme owner exists with a governance structure, budget, and delivery team

My score:

18 How capable is your finance function of managing technology vendors and implementation partners?

Vendor Mgmt

1 No experience — the team has not managed technology vendors or implementation projects

2 Limited experience — some vendor management has occurred but without a formal approach

3 Moderate experience — the team has managed vendors before and understands the basics of contract and delivery management

4 Strong experience — the team has successfully delivered technology programmes with external vendors

5 Expert — the team has a formal vendor management methodology and a track record of complex programme delivery

My score:

19 How well does your organisation manage change and embed new ways of working?

Change Mgmt

- | | |
|--|--|
| 1 Poorly — change initiatives frequently face resistance and do not embed; reversion to old ways is common | 2 Inconsistently — some changes stick, others do not; outcomes are unpredictable |
| 3 Adequately — the organisation manages change reasonably well when supported by clear communication | 4 Well — the organisation has a structured change management approach and a track record of successful adoption |
| 5 Excellently — change management is a recognised competency with dedicated resource and measurable adoption outcomes | |

My score:

20 Does your organisation have a clear AI and automation policy covering data security, permitted tools, and governance?

Governance

- | | |
|--|---|
| 1 No policy exists — tool usage is ungoverned and employees make individual decisions about what to use | 2 Informal guidelines exist but they are not comprehensive, enforced, or widely known |
| 3 A policy exists and covers the key risks, though awareness and compliance are not fully verified | 4 A formal policy exists, is communicated to all staff, and includes a review and update cycle |
| 5 A comprehensive, actively enforced governance framework exists with audit trail, training, and regular review | |

My score:

DIMENSION 4 TOTAL (MAX 25)

Scoring Summary & Readiness Level

Dimension	Your Score	Max Score
Dimension 1 — Data Quality & Availability		25
Dimension 2 — Skills & Digital Literacy		25
Dimension 3 — Process Maturity & Documentation		25
Dimension 4 — Governance & Stakeholder Readiness		25
TOTAL		100

Score	Readiness Level	What it means	Recommended next steps
20–39	Not Ready	Significant foundational gaps exist in data, skills, or governance. Automating now will embed existing problems, not solve them.	Focus on data cleansing, chart of accounts standardisation, and process documentation before any automation investment. Consider an internal readiness programme.
40–54	Early Stage	Some foundations are in place but significant gaps remain. Selective, low-risk automation is possible with careful scoping.	Pilot automation in one high-volume, well-documented process (e.g. expense processing). Address dimension gaps in parallel. Avoid complex multi-system projects until foundations improve.
55–69	Developing	Good foundations with identifiable gaps. Ready to begin a phased automation programme with appropriate governance.	Build a 12-month automation roadmap prioritised by effort-to-impact ratio. Address your lowest-scoring dimension first. Appoint an automation owner if not already in place.
70–84	Ready	Strong foundations. Ready to undertake significant automation programmes across multiple process areas with a reasonable confidence of success.	Proceed with a structured multi-workstream automation programme. Focus on advanced AI adoption (Power BI, Copilot, AI-assisted reporting). Measure adoption and ROI from day one.
85–100	Advanced	Highly mature foundations. The organisation is well positioned for advanced AI deployment, end-to-end process automation, and continuous improvement programmes.	Focus on AI-powered decision support, predictive analytics, and real-time reporting. Share learnings across the organisation. Consider whether your automation maturity is a competitive advantage worth external communication.

Note: Review your dimension scores as well as your total. A high total score with one very low dimension indicates a specific vulnerability that will constrain your automation programme — address that dimension first, regardless of overall score.

About This Resource

This assessment was compiled by **Mirela Dragulescu**, a finance transformation specialist with 9+ years delivering AI adoption programmes, T&E platform implementations, and finance process automation across 10+ European markets. The four dimensions and 20 questions reflect the readiness factors that consistently determine whether finance automation programmes succeed or fail — drawn from direct programme experience, not theoretical frameworks.

The readiness levels and recommended next steps are calibrated for European finance functions ranging from 5 to 200-person teams across multiple entities. If your context differs significantly — very small or very large teams, heavily regulated industries, or single-entity operations — adjust the interpretation accordingly.

RELATED RESOURCES

The **Finance AI Implementation Playbook** (premium, €69) takes you from readiness assessment through governance framework design, tool selection, and 90-day adoption planning — a complete implementation guide for finance functions that are ready to move. Available at **the Resources section on MD Consulting's website**.

The **AI Governance Checklist for Finance** (free) covers 15 specific governance actions to put in place before deploying AI tools with live financial data. Also available on the resources page.

AUTOMATION READINESS ADVISORY

Mirela Dragulescu Consulting offers facilitated readiness assessments, automation roadmap design, and implementation support for finance teams across European markets. If your score identifies specific gaps — in data quality, governance, or process maturity — a tailored advisory engagement can help you close them systematically before committing to platform investment.

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